Where Knowing Was Killed: A Toolkit for Modeling Epistemicide Across Historical Systems

Part I: Understanding Epistemicide and Its Traces

1. Introduction: The Concept of Epistemicide and the Imperative for a Mapping Toolkit

The historical record is replete with instances where entire systems of knowledge have been deliberately dismantled or allowed to wither through neglect and suppression. This phenomenon, termed epistemicide, extends beyond the mere loss of information; it represents the systematic destruction of a knowledge *system*—the intricate web of methods, practices, social structures, and worldviews that collectively constitute a particular way of knowing and engaging with the world.[1] The evocative phrase "killing of knowing" underscores the active, often violent, processes that target a people's capacity to produce, validate, and transmit their own understanding and heritage. This frequently involves an "unconscious dismissal" of non-Western knowledge systems, particularly within dominant Eurocentric intellectual traditions, which has had profound and lasting consequences.[1] The displacement and erasure of Indigenous and local knowledge systems are not merely historical footnotes but continue to influence global ecologies, politics, and the very fabric of cultural identity.[1]

The study of epistemicide reveals that it is rarely a singular event but rather a protracted *process*, unfolding over extended periods and employing a variety of mechanisms. Initial acts of violent destruction, such as the burning of libraries or sacred texts [2], may be followed by more insidious, institutionalized forms of suppression. These can include the banning of languages, the persecution of knowledge keepers, or the gradual replacement of indigenous systems with those of a dominant power.[3] Sometimes, elements of the targeted knowledge system are even co-opted and repurposed, stripping them of their original meaning while maintaining a semblance of continuity.[8] A systematic toolkit for mapping epistemicide is therefore crucial. While much valuable scholarship addresses epistemicide within specific historical or cultural contexts, a generalized toolkit offers a comparative and analytical framework. Such a toolkit can provide a structured methodology to identify patterns, mechanisms, and consequences of epistemicide across diverse settings, enabling a more profound understanding of how these "killings of knowing" occur and how their legacies persist. It allows for the recognition of subtle processes of undermining knowledge systems, moving beyond the focus on overt acts of destruction.

The proposed Epistemicide Mapping Toolkit aims to:

- Identify the core components (actors, artifacts, processes, socio-cultural embedding) of a targeted knowledge system.
- Profile the agents (individuals, institutions, states) and their motivations (religious, political, economic, ideological) behind epistemicidal acts.
- Map the diverse methods of knowledge destruction and suppression (direct destruction, suppression of practice, elimination of keepers, disruption of transmission, imposition of dominant systems, co-optation).
- Assess the multifaceted nature of knowledge loss, encompassing both tangible (e.g., destroyed artifacts) and intangible (e.g., lost narratives, skills, worldviews) dimensions.
- Trace strategies of resilience, adaptation, transformation, and the potential for knowledge recovery within affected communities.

By first systematically analyzing the structure, sophistication, and value of the "killed" knowledge system, this toolkit inherently challenges colonial narratives that often dismissed such systems as primitive or insignificant.[10]

This approach re-centers the intellectual heritage of marginalized peoples, shifting the focus from a passive "what was lost" to an active "what sophisticated system was deliberately dismantled." The toolkit thus serves not only as an analytical instrument but also as a means of contributing to the decolonization of historical understanding. This report will first explore the Inca knowledge system as a primary case study to illustrate these components, subsequently drawing on comparative examples before detailing the toolkit itself and its application.

2. Anatomy of a Pre-Colonial Knowledge System: The Inca Empire as a Case Study

The Inca Empire, or *Tawantinsuyu*, represents a remarkable instance of a complex civilization that managed a vast and diverse territory through sophisticated systems of administration, communication, and record-keeping, largely without an alphabetic writing system as understood in the European tradition. Understanding the anatomy of this knowledge system is crucial for comprehending the mechanisms and impact of its later disruption.

The Khipu: A Multi-layered Information System

At the heart of Inca information management was the *khipu* (also *quipu*), a complex device of knotted and colored cords.[10] These were typically made from cotton or camelid fibers (llama, alpaca), with a primary cord from which numerous pendant cords—and often subsidiary cords branching off these—were attached.[8] Information was encoded through a variety of means: the type of knots (e.g., simple overhand, long knots with multiple turns, figure-eight knots), the position of knots on the cords, the direction of the ply and twist of the cords, the colors of the cords (achieved through dyes or by selecting naturally colored fibers), and the arrangement and grouping of cords.[8]

The most clearly deciphered function of the *khipu* is numerical recording, employing a base-10 positional system.[10] Knots in specific positions represented units, tens, hundreds, and so on, allowing for the meticulous recording of census data, tribute obligations, inventories of state storehouses (*qullqas*), labor assignments (*mit'a*), and potentially calendrical information.[2] Colonial-era accounts and modern analyses, such as those by Gary Urton and the Harvard Khipu Database Project, confirm this extensive administrative use, with roughly two-thirds of the approximately 870 surviving *khipus* exhibiting standard numerical knotting patterns.[11]

However, the informational capacity of *khipus* likely extended far beyond mere numbers. Colonial chroniclers and contemporary scholars suggest that *khipus* also encoded narrative and non-numerical information, including laws, royal genealogies, historical accounts, myths, and possibly even poetry or songs.[2] Some researchers, like Urton, have proposed that *khipus* might have utilized a binary system capable of recording phonological or logographic data [4], while Frank Salomon has argued for *khipus* as a semasiographic system, where symbols represent ideas or meanings directly rather than specific sounds of a language.[4] The research of Sabine Hyland on colonial-era *khipus* from San Juan de Collata has even suggested the phonetic decipherment of names and lineage affiliations, potentially indicating an adaptation or a previously unrecognized capacity of the system.[4] This distinction between accounting and narrative *khipus* implies that a wide spectrum of "knowledge"—both quantitative for administration and qualitative for ideology and cultural memory—was entrusted to these intricate textile artifacts.[11] The potential for narrative and even phonetic encoding in *khipus*, if fully confirmed for pre-colonial devices, would fundamentally alter our understanding of Inca "literacy." It would resolve the "Inca paradox" of an empire apparently without writing, but simultaneously magnify the tragedy of the knowledge lost through colonial destruction. Such a revelation underscores a common feature of epistemicide: the dismissal of unfamiliar knowledge systems as "not writing" or "primitive," which then justifies their neglect or active destruction.

***The Quipucamayocs* (Khipu Keepers/Authorities):**

The creation, interpretation, and maintenance of *khipus* were the responsibility of highly trained specialists known as *quipucamayocs* (or *khipu kamayuq*, "khipu-authority").[2] These individuals were not mere scribes but officials who often held significant status within the Inca administration, sometimes hereditary, and were exempt from other forms of tribute or labor service due to the demanding nature of their responsibilities.[2] Their training was extensive, reportedly lasting for years, and involved memorizing vast amounts of oral information that contextualized and elaborated upon the knotted records.[2] Chronicler Felipe Guaman Poma de Ayala noted that *quipucamayocs* could "read" the *khipus* with their eyes closed, suggesting a deep, almost intuitive familiarity with their complex codes.[4] The accuracy of their records was paramount, as errors in these vital state documents could be met with severe punishment, even death.[23] The *quipucamayocs* were thus the living repositories and interpreters of a significant portion of Inca state knowledge.

The Qhapaq Ñan and Chasqui Network: Infrastructure for Knowledge Transmission

The Inca state's ability to manage its vast domain, *Tawantinsuyu*, which stretched some 40,000 kilometers along the Andes [24], was critically dependent on an extraordinary infrastructure for communication: the *Qhapaq Ñan* (Royal Road) and the *chasqui* messenger system.

Qhapaq Ñan (Inca Road System): This extensive network was a marvel of engineering, adapting to incredibly diverse and challenging terrains through the construction of stone-paved roads, stairways on steep slopes, causeways across wetlands, and sophisticated suspension bridges over deep gorges.[24] The road system, partly based on pre-Inca infrastructure and expanded and maintained through the state-organized *mit'a* labor system [25], was not merely for transport but was a powerful symbol of imperial ideology and control, linking towns, production centers, and sites of worship.[25] It facilitated the movement of armies, state officials, and goods for redistribution, and, crucially, the rapid transmission of information.[24]

***Chasquis* (Messengers):** Operating along the *Qhapaq Ñan* was a highly efficient relay system of messengers known as *chasquis*.[32] These were young men, selected for their exceptional speed, endurance, and loyalty, often from the families of local chiefs (*curacas*).[32] They underwent rigorous training from childhood, learning to navigate the difficult terrain and develop incredible stamina.[33] *Chasquis* were stationed at *chaskiwasis* (small relay huts, often circular in design [35]) or larger *tambos* (waystations offering lodging and supplies), spaced at intervals that allowed for continuous, rapid message transfer.[19]

A *chasqui* would run at top speed for his designated segment (around 1.4 km to 15 km, depending on sources and terrain) [19], carrying either memorized oral messages or *khipus* (and sometimes small, valuable items like fresh fish for the Sapa Inca).[11] It is important to note that *chasquis* were primarily carriers; the interpretation of complex *khipus* remained the domain of *quipucamayocs* at the message's destination.[11] Upon approaching the next station, the incoming *chasqui* would sound a *pututu* (conch shell trumpet) to alert the waiting runner.[19] The message or *khipu* was then exchanged, with oral messages repeated multiple times to ensure accuracy.[32] This system enabled information to travel at astonishing speeds, reportedly up to 240-300 km per day, allowing, for instance, a message from Quito to reach Cusco (a distance of about 2000 km) in about a week.[19] *Chasquis* were sustained from imperial storehouses and were not paid in currency, as the Inca economy did not operate on a monetary basis.[32] The importance of their role was underscored by the severe punishments, such as being thrown from a cliff, for delivering a message incorrectly.[33] The Quechua term *chaski* itself, meaning "reception, acceptance, consent" or "the one who exchanges" [29], hints at a symbolic function beyond mere delivery, perhaps embodying

the connective tissue that bound the disparate parts of the empire into a cohesive whole.

Oral Traditions and Somatic Knowledge:

In the absence of a widespread alphabetic script, Inca society relied profoundly on oral traditions for the transmission of history, myths, laws, and cultural values.[4] *Khipus* often served as mnemonic aids or complementary records to these oral narratives.[2] The very act of engaging with a *khipu* was likely a multi-sensory, somatic experience. Scholars like Frank Salomon and artists like Cecilia Vicuña emphasize the tactile nature of "reading" a *khipu*—feeling the knots, the texture of the fibers, the weight and structure of the cords—as being as important as visual observation of colors and arrangements.[10] Vicuña describes the *khipu* as "a poem in space, a way to remember, involving the body and the cosmos at once" [12], and Silvia Ferrara refers to it as a "corporeal system, an extension of their [the Incas'] fingers".[12] This suggests that knowledge was not just abstractly encoded but also physically embodied and experienced. Similarly, *chasquis* memorized complex oral messages, pointing to sophisticated mnemonic techniques, although the specifics of these techniques are not detailed in the available sources.[19]

Andean Cosmovision: How Worldview Shaped and Was Shaped by These Knowledge Systems

The Inca knowledge system was deeply interwoven with their cosmovision. The *Qhapaq Ñan* was perceived not merely as a network of roads but as the "veins of the empire," connecting sacred mountains (*Apus*), which were revered as powerful guardian deities.[35] For individuals like the modern *chasqui* Saturnino Ayma, running these ancient trails is a way of "inhabiting these spaces through movement, keeping ancestors' legacy alive," a profound connection to the landscape and its spiritual dimensions.[59] Andean concepts of cyclical time, the veneration of *Pachamama* (Earth Mother), and the interconnectedness of all things were reflected in and reinforced by the very landscape traversed by the *chasquis* and organized by the road system.[42]

The *khipu* itself, as a three-dimensional, tactile object, may have mirrored cosmic or social orders in its intricate structure. Its knotted cords, arranged in specific patterns and colors, can be seen as "conceptual metaphors" [12] or a "poem in space".[12] There might even be a conceptual link between the structure of *khipus* and the *ceque* system—a complex network of ritual pathways and shrines (*huacas*) that radiated from the capital, Cusco, organizing sacred space and time.[12] The rapid communication facilitated by the *chasqui* system likely shaped Inca perceptions of imperial space, effectively shrinking the vast distances of the *Tawantinsuyu* and enabling coordinated imperial actions, including the timing of empire-wide rituals and the administration of a unified state.[42]

The sophisticated integration of material artifacts like the *khipu*, human infrastructure such as the *quipucamayocs* and *chasquis*, performative elements like oral traditions and rituals, and the underlying Andean cosmovision formed the bedrock of the Inca knowledge system. Its strength lay precisely in this interconnectedness. The physical infrastructure of the *Qhapaq Ñan* and its *tambos* supported the human network, which in turn managed and interpreted the information encoded in *khipus* and oral messages. The meaning and function of these elements were inseparable from the ritual and cosmological framework of Inca society. Consequently, any disruption to one component, such as the persecution of *quipucamayocs* or the decay of the road system, would inevitably have cascading negative effects on the entire system's ability to function and preserve knowledge. Modeling epistemicide, therefore, requires a keen understanding of these interdependencies, as the "killing of knowing" is often most effective when it targets the systemic nature of knowledge rather than just its isolated components.

Furthermore, the Inca state's profound investment in and stringent control over its knowledge

infrastructure—evidenced by the monumental scale of the *Qhapaq Ñan* project, the rigorous training and state maintenance of *chasquis* and *quipucamayocs*, and restrictions on road use by commoners [2]—underscores the intrinsic link between information control and imperial power. This centralized command over the flow of information was indispensable for governing a vast and diverse empire, enabling swift responses to internal dissent, efficient allocation of resources, and the pervasive dissemination of imperial ideology. This historical precedent suggests that acts of epistemicide often involve the dismantling or co-opting of a previous regime's information control mechanisms by a new power structure aiming to establish its own authority. The Spanish targeting of *khipus* and *quipucamayocs* aligns perfectly with this pattern of seizing control over the means of knowledge production and dissemination.

Part II: Mapping the "Killing of Knowing"

3. Mechanisms of Epistemicide in the Colonial Andes

The Spanish conquest of the Inca Empire initiated a profound and multifaceted process of epistemicide, systematically dismantling the indigenous knowledge systems that had underpinned *Tawantinsuyu*. This was not a monolithic or instantaneous event but an evolving strategy involving direct destruction, suppression, co-optation, and the imposition of new colonial frameworks.

Targeting the Khipu: Spanish Colonial Policies and Ecclesiastical Condemnation

The Spanish encounter with the *khipu* was initially marked by a degree of ambivalence and even pragmatic utilization. In the early years of colonization, Spanish officials, grappling with the administration of a vast new territory and population, sometimes relied on *khipus* and the expertise of surviving *quipucamayocs*. These knotted cords were used for practical purposes such as settling tribute disputes, recording census data for colonial administration, and, remarkably, even as aids for Indigenous people making confessions to Catholic priests.[2] This period demonstrates an early recognition by the colonizers of the *khipu's* efficacy as an information management tool.

However, this utilitarian adoption soon gave way to systematic suppression and destruction, driven by a confluence of religious, political, and ideological motivations. From a religious standpoint, the Catholic Church, a powerful institution in the colonial enterprise, came to view *khipus* associated with indigenous beliefs and practices as instruments of idolatry and an impediment to Christian conversion.[3] Chroniclers and clergy often described them as "works of the devil," particularly those *khipus* that recorded "ancient superstition," pre-Christian "rites, ceremonies and laws".[70] Politically, the *khipus* represented a repository of Inca history, imperial achievements, and royal genealogies—knowledge that could affirm Inca legitimacy and potentially fuel resistance to Spanish rule.[2] Their destruction was, therefore, a means of erasing indigenous political memory and consolidating colonial authority.

The primary method of destruction was burning, and historical accounts attest to the deliberate annihilation of thousands of *khipus*.[2] This was often carried out by Spanish civil and ecclesiastical authorities, and in some instances, *quipucamayocs* themselves were forced to destroy their own records under duress.[70]

A pivotal moment in this process was the **Third Council of Lima (1582-1583)**. This influential ecclesiastical assembly issued formal decrees that explicitly condemned *khipus* associated with non-Christian beliefs and practices, ordering their systematic destruction as "pernicious instruments".[3] This council provided an institutional and theological framework for the ongoing epistemicide, legitimizing the eradication of these vital indigenous records. Intriguingly, the Third Council of Lima also encouraged the creation and use of *khipus* for specific

Christian purposes, such as aiding in confession and the memorization of doctrine.[9] This dual approach—destroying "pagan" *khipus* while sanctioning their use for Christian instruction—reveals a sophisticated colonial strategy. It was not simply about outright annihilation of the *form* of the *khipu*, which was clearly recognized as a powerful mnemonic and communicative tool within Andean societies. Rather, it was an attempt at epistemic appropriation and transformation: to empty the *khipu* of its indigenous ideological content and refill it with Christian doctrine, thereby neutralizing its potential as a site of cultural resistance and repurposing it for colonial ends. This represents a more insidious form of epistemic violence, transforming the meaning and function of a knowledge system from within. The evolving Spanish approach, from pragmatic utilization to systematic suppression and co-optation, underscores that epistemicide is often a dynamic process, with strategies shifting in response to colonial priorities, anxieties about indigenous resistance, and the perceived utility or threat of the targeted knowledge system.

Silencing the Keepers: The Persecution and Loss of *Quipucamayoc* Expertise

The destruction of the *khipus* was inextricably linked to the fate of their keepers, the *quipucamayocs*. These specialists were reportedly forced to renounce their *khipus* and their associated knowledge to avoid persecution by Spanish authorities.[70] While specific, detailed accounts of widespread, systematic persecution methods targeting *quipucamayocs* as a distinct class are not extensively detailed in the available sources beyond this forced renunciation and the general atmosphere of cultural suppression, their expertise was rendered dangerous and obsolete by the colonial regime. The knowledge of the *quipucamayocs* was profoundly embodied and often hereditary, passed down through rigorous training and long practice.[2] The destruction of the physical *khipus* inherently devalued this specialized knowledge and endangered its practitioners.

The gradual disappearance of these expert interpreters meant that the vast majority of *khipus*, particularly those believed to contain complex narrative, historical, or ritualistic information, became largely indecipherable.[2] Even in the early colonial period, chroniclers such as Felipe Guaman Poma de Ayala and Inca Garcilaso de la Vega relied on the knowledge of surviving *quipucamayocs* or the traditions they upheld for their historical accounts of the Inca past.[3] The loss of these specialists severed a vital living link to the Inca world, contributing significantly to the epistemic void. This targeting of both the records (khipus) and their expert readers/creators (*quipucamayocs*) was a strategic maneuver to dismantle the "epistemic infrastructure" of the Inca empire. By blinding and muting the Inca administrative and historical memory system, the Spanish effectively crippled its capacity for self-governance and erased precedents that might challenge colonial narratives or authority. This underscores a common pattern in epistemicide: attacking not just the "content" of knowledge but also its "conduits" and "custodians."

Severing Connections: The Disruption and Repurposing of the Chasqui Network and Qhapaq Ñan

The *Qhapaq Ñan* and the *chasqui* messenger system were the arteries through which khipu-based information and vital oral messages pulsed across the *Tawantinsuyu*.[12] The Spanish conquest and subsequent colonial policies led to the profound disruption and eventual decay of this integrated communication network. Several factors contributed to this decline: the general breakdown of centralized Inca authority during the civil war between Huascar and Atahualpa and the ensuing conquest [84]; the catastrophic depopulation of indigenous communities due to European diseases and warfare, which decimated the *mit'a* labor force essential for maintaining the roads and staffing the relay stations [24]; a fundamental shift in economic priorities under Spanish rule, with a focus on resource extraction (particularly mining) that led to the development of new transportation routes to coastal ports and the neglect of large sections of the *Qhapaq Ñan* deemed irrelevant to colonial economic interests [24]; and the introduction of European modes of transport like horses and wheeled carts, for which many of the meticulously engineered Inca roads were unsuitable.[24]

While some Spanish chroniclers expressed admiration for the efficiency of the *chasqui* system, and it was reportedly used by the Spanish in the early colonial period, sometimes deemed superior to horse-mounted messengers in the rugged Andean terrain [7], the overall integrity of the network could not be sustained under the new colonial order. The disruption of this rapid and reliable communication system had a direct and detrimental impact on the flow of all forms of information, including that encoded in *khipus*. This severance of communicative links contributed to the fragmentation of Inca administrative cohesion and the further isolation of indigenous knowledge.

Linguistic and Ritualistic Erasure: The Suppression of Quechua and Indigenous Ceremonies

The epistemicide in the Andes also involved a concerted effort to suppress indigenous languages and religious practices. The Spanish imposed their own language and religion as dominant frameworks.[41] While Quechua, the lingua franca of the Inca Empire, was initially studied by some Spanish missionaries to facilitate evangelization [5], it was later actively suppressed, particularly following indigenous uprisings such as the rebellion led by Tupac Amaru II in the late 18th century.[5] The banning of Quechua, along with indigenous attire and other cultural expressions, was a clear attempt to erase indigenous identity and assimilate the population into the colonial socio-cultural order.[5]

The destruction of *khipus* used for recording non-Christian "rites, ceremonies and laws," as mandated by bodies like the Third Council of Lima [9], was part of this broader campaign to eradicate indigenous religious practices and the cosmological knowledge they embodied. This targeted erasure of ritualistic and linguistic heritage further impoverished the Andean knowledge landscape.

The Imposition of Colonial Knowledge Frameworks

Ultimately, the Spanish colonial project involved the imposition of European knowledge frameworks. Alphabetic writing and European numeral systems were introduced and gradually replaced *khipus* in official, administrative, and increasingly, local contexts.[4] This was not merely a substitution of one set of tools for another; it represented a fundamental shift in how knowledge was conceptualized, recorded, validated, and transmitted. Indigenous epistemologies, with their emphasis on oral tradition, somatic experience, and non-alphabetic recording systems like the *khipu*, were marginalized and devalued. Even when attempts were made to "transcribe" *khipu* content into Spanish documents, this process inevitably filtered, transformed, and often misinterpreted the original indigenous meanings through a European cultural and linguistic lens [4], further contributing to the loss of authentic Inca perspectives.

4. Comparative Perspectives on Epistemicide: Identifying Cross-Cultural Patterns

The destruction of the Inca khipu system is a profound example of epistemicide, but it is not unique in world history. Examining other instances of large-scale knowledge destruction can help identify common patterns, motivations, and consequences, thereby enriching the proposed toolkit. Two notable comparative cases are the burning of Nalanda University in India and the Qin Dynasty's book burnings and burying of scholars in China.

The Burning of Nalanda University: Destruction of a Scholastic Universe

Nalanda, flourishing from the 5th century CE, was a renowned Buddhist monastic university in India, a veritable beacon of learning that attracted thousands of students and scholars from across Asia.[87] Its extensive curriculum encompassed Buddhist scriptures, philosophy, logic (*hetu vidya*), grammar, medicine (*chikitsa vidya*), astronomy, and other sciences.[87] The heart of its knowledge system was its vast library, the *Ratnodadhi*, reputed to house

hundreds of thousands, or even millions, of manuscripts.[87]

In 1193 CE, Nalanda suffered a catastrophic attack by Turkish raiders led by Bakhtiyar Khilji.[87] The motivations behind this act appear to have been a complex mix of conquest, the desire for plunder, and religious animosity towards Buddhism.[88] One account suggests Khilji's personal animosity after being healed by a Nalanda physician, which challenged his belief in the superiority of his own court's medical knowledge, leading him to seek the destruction of Ayurveda and Buddhism's roots.[87] The methods of destruction were brutal: the library was set ablaze and reportedly burned for months, thousands of monks were massacred, and the monastic buildings were ransacked.[87]

The knowledge loss was immense, with countless unique manuscripts on diverse subjects turned to ash. This event is considered a pivotal factor in the decline of Buddhism in India. Nalanda was a centralized institution, and its destruction, along with that of other Buddhist monastic universities like Vikramasila, crippled the intellectual and spiritual infrastructure of Indian Buddhism.[87] Surviving monks fled to regions like Nepal and Tibet, carrying some knowledge with them, but the tradition was severely weakened in its land of origin.[88]

The Qin Dynasty's Book Burnings and Burying of Scholars: Centralizing Imperial Ideology

In ancient China, during the reign of the first emperor Qin Shi Huang (221-210 BCE), a significant epistemicidal event occurred, famously known as the "burning of books and burying of scholars." The primary knowledge systems targeted were the diverse philosophical treatises of the "Hundred Schools of Thought" that had flourished during the preceding Warring States period, as well as historical records of the various states that Qin had conquered.[89]

The chief epistemicidal agents were Emperor Qin Shi Huang himself, acting on the advice of his chancellor, Li Si, around 213-212 BCE.[89] The primary motivation was political and ideological: to unify thought, suppress intellectual dissent that could challenge the newly established imperial authority, and consolidate the official governing philosophy of Legalism.[89] Li Si argued that scholars using records of the past to criticize the present regime and philosophers advocating different systems of governance were a threat to stability.[89]

The methods involved the commanded burning of privately held copies of historical texts (except those of Qin), poetry (like the *Classic of Poetry*), and philosophical works.[89] Books on practical subjects like medicine, divination, agriculture, and forestry were exempted.[89] Copies of the proscribed books were, according to some accounts, to be preserved in the imperial archives, accessible only to officially sanctioned scholars.[89] The "burying of scholars" traditionally refers to the execution of some 460 scholars, though modern scholarship suggests they were indeed killed, but perhaps not by being buried alive, and they were not exclusively "Confucian" scholars as that school was not yet fully distinct.[89]

The actual extent of knowledge loss is debated. The preservation of texts in imperial archives, if it occurred, would have mitigated some loss, though many of these archives were themselves destroyed in the fighting that followed the fall of the Qin Dynasty.[89] Nevertheless, the event aimed to create an ideological monopoly for Legalism and undoubtedly led to the loss of many non-Legalist philosophical texts and non-Qin historical perspectives.

Identifying Common Typologies and Comparative Insights

Comparing these cases—Inca khipus, Nalanda, and Qin Dynasty texts—reveals recurring patterns in epistemicidal

events.

1. **Targeting Centralized Repositories and Knowledge Keepers:** The destruction of Nalanda's library, the potential loss of texts from Qin imperial archives (even if initially preserved there), and the targeting of khipu archives (like those in Cusco [3]) all represent attacks on concentrated stores of knowledge. Similarly, the elimination or persecution of specialized knowledge keepers—Buddhist monks at Nalanda, scholars under the Qin, and *quipucamayocs* in the Andes—is a common tactic to cripple a knowledge system.
2. **Ideological Justifications:** In all three instances, ideological motivations were paramount. For the Spanish in the Andes, it was primarily religious (khipus as "idolatrous") and political (erasing Inca authority). For Bakhtiyar Khilji at Nalanda, religious antagonism and conquest played key roles. For Qin Shi Huang, it was the political imperative of ideological unification under Legalism.
3. **Methods of Destruction:** Burning is a strikingly common and highly symbolic method employed in all three cases, signifying a desire for complete and visible eradication.
4. **Differential Destruction:** Epistemicide is often selective. Practical or technical knowledge (e.g., agriculture and medicine in Qin China; the numerical aspects of khipus initially tolerated or even used by the Spanish) may be spared or co-opted if deemed useful or non-threatening by the dominant power. In contrast, knowledge that underpins historical consciousness, philosophical diversity, or alternative ritual frameworks—seen as challenging the new order—is frequently prioritized for destruction. This selectivity reveals much about the anxieties and strategic aims of the epistemicidal agents.

These comparisons underscore that epistemicide is frequently a strategic component of state-building, imperial consolidation, or conquest. It aims to create a unified ideology, eliminate competing narratives, and dismantle alternative power bases rooted in distinct knowledge traditions. The knowledge systems targeted are typically those perceived as upholding or representing alternative social, political, or religious orders. The "killing of knowing" is often a prelude to, or an integral part of, establishing new forms of governance and control.

Furthermore, the long-term impact of such events extends beyond the immediate loss of specific information. It invariably involves the disruption of knowledge transmission traditions, the severing of intergenerational learning, and the creation of "epistemic voids." These voids are difficult, if not impossible, to fully reconstruct, leading to lasting cultural trauma, historical distortion, and the potential for mythogenesis around the "lost" knowledge.[16] The inability to access one's own heritage from an unmediated indigenous perspective, as in the case of the largely undeciphered narrative khipus [14], is a profound and enduring consequence.

The following table provides a comparative overview:

Table 1: Comparative Overview of Knowledge Systems and Their Fates

Feature	Inca Khipu/Chasqui System	Nalanda University	Qin Dynasty Texts
Primary Media/Artifacts	Knotted Cords (*Khipu*), Oral Traditions, Road Network (*Qhapaq Ñan*)	Palm-leaf & Birch-bark Manuscripts, Oral Scholarship, Monastic Architecture	Bamboo Slips, Silk Scrolls, Oral Discourses
Key Knowledge Keepers	*Quipucamayocs*, *Chasquis*, *Amautas* (sages), Elders	Buddhist Monks, Scholars, Teachers	Scholars, Historians, Philosophers
Primary Functions	Administration (census, tribute, inventory), History, Law, Ritual, Communication	Religious & Philosophical Education, Logic, Medicine, Astronomy, Grammar	History, Philosophy, Poetry, Political Theory

Epistemicidal Agents	Spanish Colonizers (Crown, Church, Conquistadors)	Turkish Raiders (led by Bakhtiyar Khilji)	Qin Imperial State (Emperor Qin Shi Huang, Chancellor Li Si)
Primary Motivations	Religious Conversion (anti-idolatry), Political Control, Imposition of Colonial Systems	Conquest, Plunder, Religious Antagonism (anti-Buddhist)	Ideological Unification (Legalism), Suppression of Dissent, Political Consolidation
Key Methods	Burning of *Khipus*, Persecution/Loss of *Quipucamayocs*, Disruption of Chasqui Network & *Qhapaq Ñan*, Suppression of Quechua & Rituals, Imposition of Spanish Writing	Burning of Library, Massacre of Monks, Ransacking of Monastery	Burning of Books, Execution/Persecution of Scholars, Suppression of Philosophies

This comparative analysis helps to abstract generalized components for the toolkit detailed in Part III, ensuring its applicability beyond the Andean context.

Part III: The Epistemicide Mapping Toolkit – Components and Application

The Epistemicide Mapping Toolkit is designed as a heuristic framework to systematically investigate and model instances where knowledge systems have been deliberately destroyed or suppressed. It comprises five core components, each focusing on a distinct dimension of the epistemicidal process. These components are interconnected and can be applied iteratively as research progresses.

5. Core Components of the Epistemicide Mapping Toolkit

Component 1: Identifying the Knowledge System (K-System)

- **Purpose:** To comprehensively map the targeted knowledge system *before* its major disruption, understanding its internal complexity, functionality, and socio-cultural significance. This baseline understanding is crucial for assessing what was actually lost.
- **Parameters/Key Questions:**
  - **Actors:** Who are the primary creators, keepers, interpreters, and transmitters of knowledge within this system? What is their social status, how are they trained, and how is their knowledge validated and legitimized within their society?
    - *Inca Case Illustration:* The *quipucamayocs* were specialized, highly trained officials, often with hereditary roles, responsible for creating and interpreting *khipus*; they held considerable status and were integral to state administration.[2] *Chasquis* were rigorously trained runners responsible for the rapid transmission of *khipus* and oral messages.[32] *Amautas* (sages) and elders were crucial for preserving and transmitting oral traditions, history, and cosmology.[2]
  - **Artifacts/Media:** What are the material and immaterial forms through which knowledge is stored, expressed, and communicated? This includes physical objects, oral genres, performance practices, and symbolic systems.
    - *Inca Case Illustration:* The primary artifact was the *khipu*, with its complex system of knots, colors, and fibers encoding numerical and potentially narrative data.[8] Oral traditions (myths, histories, laws) were a

vital medium.[49] The *Qhapaq Ñan* itself functioned as a communicative infrastructure, facilitating the movement of knowledge.[24]

- **Processes:** How is knowledge generated, validated, recorded, transmitted, learned, updated, and contested within this system? What are the established procedures and protocols?
  - *Inca Case Illustration: Khipus* were created by *quipucamayocs* according to established conventions. Information was transmitted via the *chasqui* relay system.[32] Interpretation of *khipus* often involved an oral component, linking the knotted record to spoken narratives or explanations.[2] Knowledge was passed down through specialized training and, in some cases, hereditary lines.
- **Socio-cultural Embedding:** How is the knowledge system integrated into the broader social, political, economic, religious, and cosmological fabric of the society? How does it reflect or reinforce the society's worldview?
  - *Inca Case Illustration:* The *khipu* system was fundamental to Inca governance (tribute collection, census-taking, resource management, legal records, historical accounts).[2] The *chasqui* network was essential for imperial administration and military control.[24] Both systems were embedded within an Andean cosmovision that connected human activity to sacred landscapes and cyclical time.[12]

Component 2: Profiling Epistemicidal Agents and Motivations (E-Agents)

- **Purpose:** To identify the individuals, groups, or institutions responsible for acts of epistemicide and to understand their underlying motivations, whether explicitly stated or inferred.
- **Parameters/Key Questions:**
  - **Identifying Perpetrators:** Who are the primary agents of epistemicide? Are they internal to the society (e.g., a new ruling faction) or external (e.g., colonizers, invaders)? Are there multiple agents, and how do they interact?
    - *Inca Case Illustration:* The primary external agents were the Spanish Crown, the Catholic Church (particularly through its councils and missionary orders), individual conquistadors, and colonial administrators.[1] Internal factors, such as the Inca civil war where Atawalpa reportedly destroyed some *khipus* from Waskhar's reign, also played a role in pre-colonial knowledge alteration.[2]
  - **Analyzing Motivations:** What are the stated justifications for epistemicidal actions (e.g., religious purity, civilizing mission, national security)? What are the likely unstated or underlying goals (e.g., political subjugation, economic exploitation, cultural assimilation, elimination of ideological rivals)? Do these motivations evolve over the course of the epistemicidal process?
    - *Inca Case Illustration:* Stated motivations included religious conversion (framing *khipus* as "idolatrous" and obstacles to Christianization [3]). Underlying motivations involved political control (erasing Inca historical legitimacy and administrative structures to solidify Spanish rule [2]), economic exploitation (facilitated by dismantling the Inca administrative system that tracked resources and labor [8]), and ideological dominance (imposing European ways of knowing and governing [1]).

Component 3: Mapping Epistemicidal Methods (E-Methods)

- **Purpose:** To document the specific strategies, actions, and policies employed to destroy, suppress, or devalue the targeted knowledge system.
- **Parameters/Key Questions:**
  - **Direct Destruction of Artifacts:** What physical forms of knowledge were destroyed (e.g., books, manuscripts, records, art, architecture), and how (e.g., burning, defacement, neglect)?

    - *Inca Case Illustration:* Widespread burning of *khipus* by Spanish authorities.[2]
  - **Suppression of Practices and Languages:** Were rituals, ceremonies, educational practices, or languages associated with the knowledge system prohibited or discouraged?
    - *Inca Case Illustration:* Decrees by the Third Council of Lima against the use of *khipus* for non-Christian rites and ceremonies.[9] Suppression of the Quechua language, especially after rebellions.[5]
  - **Elimination or Persecution of Knowledge Keepers:** Were specialists killed, exiled, imprisoned, forcibly converted, discredited, or prevented from training successors?
    - *Inca Case Illustration: Quipucamayocs* were forced to renounce their *khipus* to avoid persecution.[70] While mass executions of *quipucamayocs* are not explicitly detailed as a primary method, the loss of their status and the destruction of their tools effectively eliminated their role.
  - **Disruption of Transmission Infrastructure:** Were systems for disseminating knowledge (e.g., communication networks, educational institutions, libraries, archives) dismantled, destroyed, or allowed to decay?
    - *Inca Case Illustration:* The decline and repurposing of the *Qhapaq Ñan* and the *chasqui* network due to colonial policies, depopulation, and changing economic priorities.[24]
  - **Imposition of Dominant Knowledge Systems:** Was a new knowledge system (language, script, educational curriculum, legal framework) forcibly imposed, thereby marginalizing or replacing the indigenous one?
    - *Inca Case Illustration:* Imposition of the Spanish language, alphabetic writing, and European administrative and legal systems.[5]
  - **Co-optation and Transformation:** Were elements of the indigenous knowledge system appropriated by the dominant power but stripped of their original meaning or repurposed for new ends?
    - *Inca Case Illustration:* Spanish administrative use of *khipus* for tribute and census records in the early colonial period [7]; the Third Council of Lima's encouragement of *khipus* for Christian confession and doctrinal memorization.[9]

Component 4: Assessing Knowledge Loss (K-Loss)

- **Purpose:** To evaluate the nature, scope, and multifaceted impact of the knowledge that was destroyed, suppressed, or made inaccessible.
- **Parameters/Key Questions:**
  - **Tangible Losses:** What is the quantifiable extent of destruction (e.g., number of artifacts destroyed, sites razed, specialists lost)?
    - *Inca Case Illustration:* Thousands of *khipus* were destroyed; estimates suggest only around 870 to 1,400 survive today from what was likely a vastly larger corpus.[2]
  - **Intangible Losses:** What specific types of knowledge are believed to have been lost or severely diminished (e.g., historical narratives, genealogies, scientific understanding, artistic traditions, ritual procedures, legal precedents, philosophical concepts)?
    - *Inca Case Illustration:* Significant loss of detailed administrative records, specific historical accounts from an Inca perspective, royal genealogies, laws, cosmological understandings, and potentially a unique form of non-alphabetic literacy if narrative *khipus* were indeed widespread.[2] The loss of the "Inca viewpoint" on their own world and history.[14]
  - **The Epistemic Void:** What can no longer be known or understood from the perspective of the targeted culture due to this loss? How does this absence distort historical understanding and contemporary knowledge?

        - *Inca Case Illustration:* The full complexity of *khipu* encoding, especially for non-numerical information, remains largely undeciphered, creating a significant gap in understanding Inca intellectual achievements and societal organization from their own framework.[14]
    - **Impact on Community:** What were the short-term and long-term consequences for the affected community's social cohesion, cultural identity, governance, economic practices, spiritual well-being, and ability to adapt to new challenges?
        - *Inca Case Illustration:* Disruption of administrative systems, fragmentation of historical memory, erosion of cultural identity, and the imposition of a colonial social and political order.[22]

Component 5: Tracing Resilience and Transformation (R-Strategies)

- **Purpose:** To identify and analyze the ways in which targeted communities resisted epistemicide, adapted their knowledge systems, preserved knowledge through alternative or clandestine means, or how knowledge persisted in transformed forms. This also includes examining modern efforts at knowledge recovery and revitalization.
- **Parameters/Key Questions:**
    - **Adaptation and Syncretism:** Did elements of the indigenous knowledge system become integrated (often in altered form) into the dominant system, or did syncretic forms of knowledge emerge?
        - *Inca Case Illustration:* Early Spanish administrative adoption of *khipus* [4]; the Church's attempt to use *khipus* for Christian instruction.[9]
    - **Clandestine Preservation and Local Persistence:** Did knowledge keepers or communities continue to practice or transmit knowledge in secret or in localized contexts, away from official scrutiny?
        - *Inca Case Illustration:* Continued use of *khipus* for local, intracommunity record-keeping and ritual purposes in some remote Andean communities well into the colonial period and even up to the 20th century or later.[2]
    - **Oral Tradition as a Vehicle of Resilience:** How did oral traditions (storytelling, song, ritual recitation) serve to maintain and transmit knowledge when material forms were destroyed or suppressed?
        - *Inca Case Illustration:* The persistence of Andean oral traditions carrying historical memories, myths, and cultural values, even if fragmented or transformed.[22]
    - **Somatic Memory and Embodied Practices:** How is knowledge preserved and transmitted through bodily practices, rituals, craft traditions, agricultural techniques, or community life, even if not explicitly articulated as formal knowledge?
        - *Inca Case Illustration:* The ethnographic work of scholars like Frank Salomon and Sabine Hyland has documented the enduring significance of *khipus* (or their memory) in the ritual life and somatic practices of certain Andean communities, where they may function as symbols of communal identity, authority, or sacred heritage.[10] The physical act of tying knots or weaving can itself be a form of embodied knowledge.
    - **Modern Revitalization and Decipherment Efforts:** What contemporary initiatives are underway by scholars, communities, or institutions to study, reclaim, decipher, or revitalize elements of the suppressed knowledge system?
        - *Inca Case Illustration:* The Harvard Khipu Database Project [11]; ongoing scholarly research by individuals like Gary Urton, Sabine Hyland, Frank Salomon, and Manuel Medrano aimed at deciphering *khipu* codes and understanding their function [4]; community-led efforts to preserve khipu traditions or incorporate khipu knowledge into local education.[17]

The application of this toolkit is not a strictly linear process; the components are interconnected and often require

iterative investigation. For instance, a deeper understanding of knowledge loss (K-Loss) can refine the search for resilience strategies (R-Strategies), while identifying the motivations of epistemicidal agents (E-Agents) can clarify the methods they employed (E-Methods). "Resilience" itself can be a complex and sometimes paradoxical phenomenon. It may include forms of co-optation by the dominant power that preserve certain aspects of a knowledge system (like the form of the *khipu*) while fundamentally altering its original meaning, control, or ideological content, as seen in the Spanish use of *khipus* for colonial administration or Christian confession.[7] The toolkit must therefore critically analyze what "resilience" signifies in each specific context—whether it represents active resistance and preservation of indigenous meaning, or an adaptation that involves significant compromise and re-inscription by the dominant power. This nuanced understanding is vital for grasping the long-term trajectory of knowledge systems under duress.

Furthermore, particularly for cultures where oral and performative traditions are central, the study of somatic memory and embodied practices (a key aspect of R-Strategies) becomes crucial for understanding knowledge persistence, especially when material records like the *khipus* have been largely destroyed.[2] Knowledge elements that were once tied to *khipus* or transmitted by *chasquis* could persist in communal rituals, storytelling, craft techniques (like weaving), agricultural practices, or an embodied understanding of the landscape. The work of Salomon and Hyland in contemporary or recent Andean communities provides compelling evidence of this embodied persistence.[15] The toolkit must therefore incorporate methodologies for identifying and analyzing these less tangible forms of knowledge survival, moving beyond an exclusive focus on textual or artifactual evidence.

Table 2: Components of the Epistemicide Mapping Toolkit with Illustrative Inca Examples

Toolkit Component	Key Questions/Parameters	Inca Case Illustration
1. K-System Identification: Actors	Who creates, keeps, transmits knowledge? Training? Social status?	*Quipucamayocs*: specialized, trained, often hereditary, high status officials, severe punishment for errors.[2] *Chasquis*: young, fit, trained runners for khipu/oral message relay.[32] *Amautas*/Elders: oral traditions, history, cosmology.[2]
1. K-System Identification: Artifacts/Media	Material/immaterial forms of knowledge storage/expression? Characteristics?	*Khipu*: knotted/colored cords (cotton/camelid fibers) for numerical & narrative data.[8] Oral traditions: myths, histories, laws.[49] *Qhapaq Ñan*: communicative infrastructure.[24]
1. K-System Identification: Processes	How is knowledge created, recorded, transmitted, interpreted, learned, updated? Rituals involved?	*Khipu* creation by *quipucamayocs*. Transmission by *chasqui* relay.[32] *Khipu* interpretation often with oral component.[2] Hereditary/specialized training.
1. K-System Identification: Socio-cultural Embedding	Integration into governance, economy, religion, social structure, daily life? Worldview reflected/reinforced?	*Khipu* for tribute, census, law, history.[2] *Chasqui* network for imperial administration, military control.[24] Andean

		cosmovision: sacred landscapes, cyclical time.[12]
2. E-Agent Profiling: Perpetrators	Primary agents (individuals, institutions, states)? Internal/external? Interactions?	External: Spanish Crown, Catholic Church, conquistadors, colonial administrators.[1] Internal: Atawalpa destroying some rival *khipus*.[2]
2. E-Agent Profiling: Motivations	Stated/unstated goals? Religious, political, economic, ideological? Evolving?	Religious conversion (anti-idolatry).[3] Political control (erasing Inca history/legitimacy).[2] Economic exploitation.[8] Ideological dominance (imposing European ways of knowing).[1]
3. E-Method Mapping: Direct Destruction	Physical annihilation of artifacts? How?	Burning of *khipus* by Spanish authorities.[2]
3. E-Method Mapping: Suppression of Practice	Prohibition of artifacts, languages, rituals?	Third Council of Lima decrees against *khipus* for non-Christian rites.[9] Suppression of Quechua.[5]
3. E-Method Mapping: Elimination/Persecution of Keepers	Killing, exiling, discrediting, preventing training?	*Quipucamayocs* forced to renounce *khipus*.[70] Loss of status and role.
3. E-Method Mapping: Disruption of Transmission Infrastructure	Dismantling/neglect of communication networks, institutions?	Decline/repurposing of *Qhapaq Ñan* and *chasqui* network.[24]
3. E-Method Mapping: Imposition of Dominant Systems	Forcing adoption of colonizer's language, writing, education?	Imposition of Spanish language, alphabetic script, European administrative systems.[5]
3. E-Method Mapping: Co-optation/Transformation	Appropriating indigenous forms but altering content/meaning?	Spanish use of *khipus* for colonial administration.[7] *Khipus* for Christian confession.[9]
4. K-Loss Assessment: Tangible Losses	Quantifiable destruction (artifacts, sites, specialists)?	Thousands of *khipus* destroyed; only ~870-1400 survive.[2]
4. K-Loss Assessment: Intangible Losses	Types of knowledge lost (history, narratives, laws, science, ritual)? Loss of specific perspectives?	Detailed administrative records, historical narratives, genealogies, laws, cosmological understandings, potential non-alphabetic literacy.[2] Loss of "Inca viewpoint".[14]
4. K-Loss Assessment: Epistemic Void	What can no longer be known? How does	Full complexity of *khipu* encoding

	this distort historical understanding?	(especially non-numerical) remains largely undeciphered, hindering understanding of Inca intellect/society from their perspective.[14]
4. K-Loss Assessment: Impact on Community	Consequences for social cohesion, identity, governance, economy, spirituality, adaptation?	Disruption of administration, fragmented historical memory, eroded cultural identity, imposition of colonial order.[22]
5. R-Strategy Tracing: Adaptation/Syncretism	Indigenous knowledge integrated into dominant system? Syncretic forms?	Spanish administrative use of *khipus*.[7] *Khipus* for Christian confession.[9]
5. R-Strategy Tracing: Clandestine Preservation/Local Persistence	Knowledge practices continued in secret or locally?	Continued local/ritual use of *khipus* in some Andean communities.[2]
5. R-Strategy Tracing: Oral Tradition as Resilience	How did oral traditions maintain knowledge when material forms were suppressed?	Persistence of Andean oral traditions carrying historical memories, myths, cultural values.[22]
5. R-Strategy Tracing: Somatic Memory/Embodied Practices	Knowledge preserved in bodily practices, rituals, crafts, community life?	Enduring significance of *khipus* in ritual life, somatic practices in some Andean communities (Salomon, Hyland).[10]
5. R-Strategy Tracing: Modern Revitalization/Decipherment	Contemporary efforts to study, reclaim, decipher, revitalize lost knowledge?	Khipu Database Project.[11] Research by Urton, Hyland, Salomon, Medrano.[3] Community efforts to preserve/teach khipu traditions.[17]

6. Applying the Toolkit: Modeling Epistemicide in Historical Systems

The true utility of the Epistemicide Mapping Toolkit lies in its application to specific historical cases, allowing for the development of nuanced models that illuminate the complex dynamics of knowledge destruction and resilience. These models can take various forms, both visual and narrative, to capture the multifaceted nature of epistemicide.

Developing Visual and Narrative Models

Visual modeling can be particularly effective in revealing patterns and connections that might be less apparent through textual analysis alone. For instance:

- **Timelines:** Mapping the sequence of epistemicidal events, colonial policies, ecclesiastical decrees, indigenous rebellions, and resistance strategies over decades or centuries can illustrate the evolving nature of the conflict over knowledge.
- **Network Diagrams:** These can visually represent the interconnectedness of actors (e.g., *quipucamayocs*, *chasquis*, colonial officials), artifacts (*khipus* of different types), and processes (e.g., tribute collection, ritual performance, message relay) within the indigenous knowledge system. Subsequent diagrams can then show how specific epistemicidal methods (e.g., burning of *khipus*, disruption of the *chasqui* network) severed these

crucial connections, highlighting the systemic impact.

- **Flowcharts:** These can depict the original pathways of knowledge creation, validation, and transmission within the indigenous system and then illustrate how these flows were blocked, rerouted, or replaced by colonial mechanisms.
- **Geospatial Maps:** Crucially, for a toolkit titled "Where Knowing Was Killed," geospatial mapping can pinpoint the geographical locations of significant epistemicidal events. This could include sites of documented *khipu* burnings, regions where *quipucamayoc* communities were concentrated and subsequently dispersed, areas where the *Qhapaq Ñan* and its *tambos* fell into disuse or were repurposed, or zones of intense missionary activity aimed at eradicating indigenous rituals. Such maps can reveal geographic concentrations of destruction or highlight regions where certain types of knowledge (e.g., local governance records versus imperial histories) were more heavily targeted, offering insights into the specific strategic aims of epistemicidal agents.

Narrative models, in the form of detailed case studies, weave together the findings from each of the five toolkit components. They provide a rich, contextualized account of how a specific knowledge system was targeted, the methods employed, the scope of the loss, and the ways in which communities resisted or adapted.

Case Study Application: A Detailed Model of Epistemicide in the Inca Empire

Applying the toolkit to the Inca Empire, as detailed in previous sections, provides a comprehensive model:

- **K-System (Inca):** A highly sophisticated and integrated system relying on the *khipu* for diverse record-keeping (numerical and likely narrative) [2]; specialized *quipucamayocs* for their creation and interpretation [2]; the vast *Qhapaq Ñan* and swift *chasqui* messenger network for information transmission [24]; all deeply embedded in oral traditions and Andean cosmovision.[12]
- **E-Agents (Inca):** Primarily Spanish colonial authorities (civil and ecclesiastical) and conquistadors.[1] Motivations included religious conversion (eradicating "idolatry"), political subjugation (destroying Inca administrative and historical records), economic exploitation, and the imposition of European cultural and epistemic norms.[1]
- **E-Methods (Inca):** Systematic burning of *khipus*, particularly those related to indigenous religion and law [2]; forced renunciation and loss of *quipucamayoc* expertise [70]; disruption and decay of the *Qhapaq Ñan* and *chasqui* network [24]; suppression of the Quechua language and indigenous rituals [5]; and the imposition of Spanish alphabetic literacy and administrative practices, including the co-optation of *khipus* for colonial purposes.[7]
- **K-Loss (Inca):** Devastating loss of the vast majority of *khipus* and the inability to fully decipher many surviving examples, particularly their potential narrative content.[2] This resulted in the loss of detailed administrative records, unique historical perspectives, genealogies, laws, and potentially an entire non-alphabetic literacy system, creating a profound epistemic void regarding the Inca understanding of their own world.[2]
- **R-Strategies (Inca):** Continued local and ritualistic use of *khipus* in some Andean communities [7]; the recording of Inca history and traditions by chroniclers like Guaman Poma and Garcilaso de la Vega, albeit filtered through colonial lenses [3]; and ongoing modern scholarly efforts to decipher *khipus* and understand their complex functions, often in collaboration with descendant communities.[4]

Brief Application Sketches for Nalanda and Qin Dynasty:

- **Nalanda University:**

- **K-System:** Vast monastic university, extensive library of manuscripts (Buddhist philosophy, logic, medicine, etc.), community of monks and scholars.[87]
- **E-Agents:** Turkish raiders (Bakhtiyar Khilji).[87] Motivations: conquest, plunder, religious antagonism.[87]
- **E-Methods:** Burning of library, massacre of monks, destruction of monastic infrastructure.[87]
- **K-Loss:** Immense loss of manuscripts and scholarly expertise, decline of Buddhist intellectual tradition in India.[87]
- **R-Strategies:** Flight of surviving monks to other regions (e.g., Tibet, Nepal), preserving some texts and traditions abroad; later archaeological rediscovery.[88]

- **Qin Dynasty Book Burnings:**
  - **K-System:** Philosophical texts of Hundred Schools of Thought, historical records of pre-Qin states, poetry.[89]
  - **E-Agents:** Qin imperial state (Emperor Qin Shi Huang, Chancellor Li Si).[89] Motivations: ideological unification (Legalism), suppression of dissent.[89]
  - **E-Methods:** Burning of privately held books, execution/persecution of scholars, preservation of some texts in imperial archives (later burned) and exemption of technical books.[89]
  - **K-Loss:** Debated extent, but significant loss of non-Legalist philosophical texts and non-Qin historical records, narrowing of intellectual discourse.[89]
  - **R-Strategies:** Oral transmission, potential hidden copies, later Han Dynasty efforts to reconstruct texts, scholarly debate and reinterpretation of the event itself.[89]

Applying the toolkit comparatively in this manner not only validates its robustness across different cultural and historical settings but also aids in constructing a more nuanced, cross-cultural theory of epistemicide. By systematically examining each case through the same analytical lenses (K-System, E-Agents, E-Methods, K-Loss, R-Strategies), it becomes possible to identify recurrent typologies of attack (e.g., targeting knowledge keepers, destroying central repositories) and resilience (e.g., oral transmission, clandestine preservation). This comparative approach allows for the formulation of hypotheses regarding, for example, whether epistemicide driven by religious fervor exhibits different patterns of destruction than that motivated by purely political consolidation, or whether decentralized knowledge systems demonstrate greater resilience compared to highly centralized ones. The toolkit thus moves beyond individual case studies to contribute to a broader theoretical understanding of how knowledge systems emerge, thrive, are threatened, and transform under pressure.

Part IV: Implications and Future Directions

7. The Enduring Impact of Epistemicide: Memory, Identity, and Justice

The consequences of epistemicide reverberate far beyond the immediate period of destruction, profoundly shaping the collective memory, cultural identity, and pursuit of justice for affected communities over generations. The "killing of knowing" is not a closed historical chapter but an ongoing process whose legacies continue to unfold.

Shaping Collective Memory and Cultural Identity

The loss of indigenous knowledge systems, such as the Inca *khipu* and its associated oral traditions, directly impacts a community's capacity to construct, maintain, and transmit its own history and cultural narratives from an internal perspective.[22] When the primary records and the specialists who could interpret them are eliminated, an "epistemic void" is created. This void is often subsequently filled by the narratives of the colonizing or dominant

power, leading to a distorted historical understanding where the perspectives and achievements of the subjugated are marginalized or erased. Alternatively, mythogenesis can occur around the lost knowledge, where fragmented memories and speculations blend to create new, sometimes romanticized or inaccurate, understandings of the past.[16]

Despite such profound losses, fragments of suppressed knowledge systems and resilient practices often persist. In the Andean context, this includes the continued, albeit transformed, use of *khipus* in some local communities for ritual or record-keeping purposes, the enduring power of oral traditions to carry cultural memory, and the preservation of knowledge through somatic memory embodied in rituals, craft skills (like weaving), agricultural techniques, and a deep connection to the landscape.[7] These surviving elements, however altered, can become crucial touchstones for maintaining a connection to pre-colonial identity and resisting complete cultural assimilation. The very act of systematically mapping historical epistemicide, as facilitated by this toolkit, can itself be an act of epistemic recovery and resistance. By meticulously documenting the sophistication of the "killed" knowledge system and the deliberate methods used to dismantle it, this process inherently challenges the dominant narratives that often justified or obscured such destruction. It re-values the intellectual heritage of the marginalized and shifts the focus from a passive narrative of "loss" to an active recognition of "what was taken."

The Ethics of Researching and Representing "Killed Knowledge"

Engaging with the remnants of "killed knowledge" carries significant ethical responsibilities for researchers. There is a moral imperative to avoid extractive research practices where information is taken from communities without due respect, collaboration, or benefit to them. Instead, collaborative approaches, such as those exemplified by anthropologist Sabine Hyland's work with Andean communities where she respects local protocols and contributes to local educational initiatives [17], are essential. Researchers must acknowledge the trauma associated with epistemicide and approach the subject with sensitivity and humility.

Furthermore, the interpretation of fragmented or decontextualized knowledge presents profound challenges. Deciphering *khipus* without the full context of their original oral components or the living expertise of *quipucamayocs* is an arduous task, fraught with the potential for misinterpretation.[12] Researchers must be transparent about these limitations and engage critically with the power dynamics inherent in representing the knowledge of others, particularly those whose voices have been historically silenced. Modern efforts to decipher lost knowledge, such as the ongoing work on *khipus* by numerous scholars [4], are not merely academic exercises. They can have profound implications for the cultural identity and revitalization efforts of descendant communities. Breakthroughs in understanding these ancient systems can foster pride, reconnect communities with their ancestral heritage, and provide new material for cultural education and expression.[7] Therefore, research in this area should ideally be conducted in partnership with, and in service to, the communities whose heritage is being studied.

The Role of Toolkits in Contemporary Struggles for Epistemic Justice and Decolonization of Knowledge

Understanding historical epistemicide, through frameworks like the one proposed here, has direct relevance to contemporary struggles for epistemic justice and the decolonization of knowledge. The patterns of suppression, marginalization, and misrepresentation observed in historical cases often find echoes in modern contexts. This toolkit can help inform efforts to decolonize curricula, research methodologies, and academic institutions by highlighting the value of diverse knowledge systems and the historical processes that have led to their marginalization.

By providing a means to systematically analyze and articulate the value of suppressed knowledge systems, such toolkits can empower marginalized communities in their efforts to reclaim, revalue, and revitalize their own

intellectual and cultural heritage. This connects directly to broader issues of linguistic human rights, the preservation of cultural patrimony, and the pursuit of indigenous self-determination.[1] The fight against epistemicide is ongoing, and historical understanding is a vital tool in that struggle.

8. Conclusion: Towards a Deeper Understanding of Lost Worlds of Knowing

The Epistemicide Mapping Toolkit presented in this report offers an analytical framework designed to facilitate a systematic and comparative study of the destruction and suppression of knowledge systems across diverse historical and cultural landscapes. By deconstructing the process into core components—identifying the targeted knowledge system (K-System), profiling epistemicidal agents and motivations (E-Agents), mapping epistemicidal methods (E-Methods), assessing knowledge loss (K-Loss), and tracing strategies of resilience and transformation (R-Strategies)—the toolkit aims to reveal the complex patterns, mechanisms, and far-reaching consequences of such "killings of knowing." The detailed application to the Inca khipu/chasqui system, alongside comparative sketches of Nalanda University and the Qin Dynasty book burnings, demonstrates its potential utility.

The study of historical epistemicide, far from being a purely academic endeavor, offers critical lessons for contemporary societies. We currently grapple with our own challenges related to the control of information, the spread of misinformation and disinformation, the silencing of dissenting voices through various means (including algorithmic bias in the digital age), and the persistent marginalization of certain forms of knowledge, particularly those that fall outside dominant scientific or Western paradigms. The historical patterns of epistemicide—the targeting of knowledge keepers, the strategic control of transmission channels, the discrediting of alternative narratives, and the imposition of singular ideological frameworks—find disquieting parallels in modern contexts, albeit enacted through different technologies and by different agents. A nuanced understanding of how epistemicide has operated in the past can equip us to better identify, analyze, and resist its contemporary manifestations, thereby fostering a more inclusive, equitable, and resilient global knowledge ecosystem.

The enduring mystery of undeciphered knowledge systems, such as the narrative dimensions of many Inca *khipus* [12], serves as a poignant reminder of what can be irrevocably lost when a society's way of knowing is extinguished. Yet, the persistent efforts of scholars and descendant communities to study, decipher, and reclaim these lost intellectual traditions [4] testify to the profound human value placed on understanding our collective past and the diverse ways cultures have constructed meaning. This endeavor is not merely about recovering historical curiosities; it is an ethical imperative to acknowledge, respect, and learn from the myriad "worlds of knowing" that constitute our shared human heritage, especially those that have been violently suppressed. The toolkit proposed here is offered as one contribution to this ongoing project of intellectual recovery, critical understanding, and epistemic justice. The journey into "where knowing was killed" is ultimately a journey towards a more comprehensive appreciation of human intellectual diversity and the enduring resilience of the human spirit in its quest to remember, understand, and transmit knowledge across generations.

Further research should involve the application of this toolkit to a wider array of historical cases, including the destruction of the Library of Alexandria, the impact of colonialism on indigenous knowledge systems globally, and the effects of ideological purges on scientific, artistic, and philosophical traditions in various regimes. Such applications will not only test and refine the toolkit itself but also contribute to a more robust comparative understanding of epistemicide, potentially leading to more effective strategies for safeguarding epistemic diversity in the present and future.

Works cited

1. Postcolonial Knowledges, accessed May 18, 2025, https://postcolonialinterventions.com/wp-content/uploads/2022/02/jan-20201-m

aster-may-17.pdf
2. Quipu: The Inca String Record-Keeping Device - World History ..., accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.worldhistory.org/Quipu/
3. www.rahf.es, accessed May 18, 2025, http://www.rahf.es/wp-content/uploads/2015/01/The_Quipu_of_the_Incas.pdf
4. Quipu - Wikipedia, accessed May 18, 2025, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Quipu
5. Quechua: A Dead Language? Not at All | TheCollector, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.thecollector.com/quechua-dead-language/
6. Quechua speaking countries - Worlddata.info, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.worlddata.info/languages/quechua.php
7. Quipu: South America's Ancient Writing System - ThoughtCo, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.thoughtco.com/introduction-to-quipu-inca-writing-system-172285
8. Quipu: How Did the Inca Record Information with Cords & Knots ..., accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.thecollector.com/inca-empire-record-information-quipu/
9. Third Council of Lima - Wikipedia, accessed May 18, 2025, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Third_Council_of_Lima
10. Quipu - Latin American Studies - Oxford Bibliographies, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.oxfordbibliographies.com/abstract/document/obo-9780199766581/obo-9780199766581-0175.xml
11. Managing the strings of power: functions of the quipu in the Inca empire, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.eltraductoringles.com/PDFs/Funciones%20de%20los%20quipus%20en%20el%20Imperio%20inca.pdf
12. QUIPU PROCEDURE - Amodern, accessed May 18, 2025, https://amodern.net/article/quipu-procedure/
13. The quipu is most commonly known as the numeric recording system of the Inca Empire which extended across Peru and parts of Chil, accessed May 18, 2025, https://etnomatematica.org/publica/articulos/Quipu%20-%20Tun%202014.pdf
14. Quipus, The Inca Language of Knots | National Endowment for the ..., accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.neh.gov/project/quipus-inca-language-knots
15. The Cord Keepers: Khipus and Cultural Life in a Peruvian Village. Frank Salomon. Durham: Duke University Press - IU ScholarWorks, accessed May 18, 2025, https://scholarworks.iu.edu/journals/index.php/mar/article/download/21/37/166
16. Is there ongoing work on decoding quipu? : r/AskHistorians - Reddit, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.reddit.com/r/AskHistorians/comments/1hkbneb/is_there_ongoing_work_on_decoding_quipu/
17. Anthropologist Sabine Hyland on Khipus, the Chanka, and Fieldwork in the Andes, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.keyreporter.org/articles/2020/the-andean-adventures-of-anthropologist-sabine-hyland/
18. Writing with Twisted Cords: The Inscriptive Capacity of Andean Khipus - ResearchGate, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.researchgate.net/publication/316265905_Writing_with_Twisted_Cord

s_The_Inscriptive_Capacity_of_Andean_Khipus
19. The Chaski - Smithsonian Institution, accessed May 18, 2025, https://americanindian.si.edu/inkaroad/pdf/inka-teachers-guide.pdf
20. Historians Of The Incas - Accounting Information, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.accountingin.com/accounting-historians-journal/volume-10-number-2/the-accountant-historians-of-the-incas/
21. The Quipus and The Royal Commentaries of the Inca by Garcilaso de la Vega - GoGeometry, accessed May 18, 2025, https://gogeometry.com/incas1/quipu/quipu_royal_commentaries_inca_garcilaso.html
22. 10.7 Quipu narratives - World Literature I - Fiveable, accessed May 18, 2025, https://library.fiveable.me/world-literature-i/unit-10/quipu-narratives/study-guide/9DOwtwoSMAyWNNoe
23. The application of Incakhipuas an accountability and managerial control tool - SciELO, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.scielo.br/j/rbgn/a/VQGGsWxCHv5DpJXGLWcVnnv/?format=pdf&lang=en
24. Inca road system - Wikipedia, accessed May 18, 2025, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Inca_road_system
25. Qhapaq Ñan, Andean Road System - UNESCO World Heritage Centre, accessed May 18, 2025, https://whc.unesco.org/en/list/1459/
26. Inca Roads and Chasquis - Discover Peru, accessed May 18, 2025, http://www.discover-peru.org/inca-roads-chasqui/
27. The Inca labor system and Mita obligations (Updated 2025), accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.quechuasexpeditions.com/the-inca-labor-system-and-mita-obligations/
28. Incas, The | Encyclopedia.com, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.encyclopedia.com/humanities/encyclopedias-almanacs-transcripts-and-maps/incas
29. The Chasquis: Ancient Messengers of the Inca Empire's Qhapaq Ñan (Inca Trails), accessed May 18, 2025, https://trexperienceperu.com/blog/chasquis-ancient-messengers-inca-empires-qhapaq-nan-inca-trails
30. Inca road system - Wikiwand, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.wikiwand.com/en/articles/Inca_road_system
31. Inca Trade Networks: Importance & Geography | Vaia, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.vaia.com/en-us/explanations/archaeology/arcaheology-of-trade/inca-trade-networks/
32. Chasqui - Wikipedia, accessed May 18, 2025, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Chasqui
33. Inca Encyclopedia Block C [licensed for non-commercial use only ..., accessed May 18, 2025, http://incaencyclopediac.pbworks.com/w/page/21051595/Chasqi%20Runners
34. The Chaski: Swift Messengers of the Inca Empire - Blog Viagens Machu Picchu, accessed May 18, 2025,

https://blog.viajesmachupicchu.travel/en/the-chaski-swift-messengers-of-the-inca-empire/
35. Raqchi and the Temple of the God Wiracocha | TreXperience, accessed May 18, 2025, https://trexperienceperu.com/blog/raqchi-and-temple-god-wiracocha
36. Tambo (Inca structure) - Wikipedia, accessed May 18, 2025, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Tambo_(Inca_structure)
37. Huánuco Pampa, one of the hubs along the Inca Road network - SA ..., accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.saexpeditions.com/blog/post/huanuco-pampa-and-the-logistics-hubs-which-fed-an-empire
38. Peru_Geography_Chasqui Relay Race of the Inca Empire.pdf - Latin American Studies, accessed May 18, 2025, https://clas.arizona.edu/sites/default/files/Peru_Geography_Chasqui%20Relay%20Race%20of%20the%20Inca%20Empire.pdf
39. Who were the chasquis? - PeruSIM, accessed May 18, 2025, https://perusim.com/blog/who-were-the-chasquis/
40. Inca Chasqui Relay Roadrunners Revolutionized Communication - Ancient Origins, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.ancient-origins.net/weird-facts/chasqui-0020074
41. How was the Inca communication? - Ticket Machu Picchu, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.ticketmachupicchu.com/inca-government-organization-system/
42. Chaski Inca: The swift messengers who united the empire, accessed May 18, 2025, https://perugrandtravel.com/blog/cusco/chaski-inca-the-swift-messengers
43. Where was the Inca Empire? - Q-files - Search • Read • Discover, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.q-files.com/history/lets-explore-ancient-worlds/where-was-the-inca-empire
44. The Inca Empire's Silent Couriers: The Chasquis - Peruways, accessed May 18, 2025, https://peruways.com/the-inca-empires-silent-couriers-the-chasquis/
45. Administration of the Inca Empire | World Civilization - Lumen Learning, accessed May 18, 2025, https://courses.lumenlearning.com/suny-hccc-worldcivilization/chapter/administration-of-the-inca-empire/
46. (PDF) Kichwa orality, past and present from the educational, anthropological and cultural perspective - ResearchGate, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.researchgate.net/publication/360603157_Kichwa_orality_past_and_present_from_the_educational_anthropological_and_cultural_perspective
47. History of the Inca Empire - ThoughtCo, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.thoughtco.com/inca-empire-south-americas-kings-171308
48. Who Were The Chaskis? The Messengers Of The Andes - Auri Peru, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.auriperu.com/blog/who-were-the-chaskis
49. Incan oral traditions | World Literature I Class Notes - Fiveable, accessed May 18, 2025, https://fiveable.me/world-literature-i/unit-10/incan-oral-traditions/study-guide/m

wcdv79fREmDlEIa
50. South American Myths, Legends and Lullabies - Hatching Dragons, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.hatching-dragons.com/en-gb/blog/south-american-myths-legends-and-lullabies
51. The Inca Khipu: Unraveling Ancient Knot-Based Records - Evolution Of The Progress, accessed May 18, 2025, https://evolutionoftheprogress.com/the-inca-khipu/
52. QUIPU PROJECT IN PERU - Bertha Foundation, accessed May 18, 2025, https://berthafoundation.org/story/quipu-project-in-peru/
53. The Andean Khipu in Context with other Knotted String Traditions of the Americas, accessed May 18, 2025, https://as.nyu.edu/departments/ancientstudies/events/fall-2023/the-andean-khipu-in-context-with-other-knotted-string-traditions.html
54. The khipu board of Mangas. Photo by Sabine Hyland. - ResearchGate, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.researchgate.net/figure/The-khipu-board-of-Mangas-Photo-by-Sabine-Hyland_fig2_352412780
55. Cord Keepers - Dumbarton Oaks Museum Shop, accessed May 18, 2025, https://shop.doaks.org/cord-keepers.html
56. Khipus, Khipu Boards, and Sacred Texts: Toward a Philology of Andean Knotted Cords | Latin American Research Review - Cambridge University Press & Assessment, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.cambridge.org/core/journals/latin-american-research-review/article/khipus-khipu-boards-and-sacred-texts-toward-a-philology-of-andean-knotted-cords/61B91DF0E21873EFE260B7B61A1B8AF9
57. Recuperative Archives, Critical Resistance, and the History of the Senses in the Atlantic World - Oxford Research Encyclopedias, accessed May 18, 2025, https://oxfordre.com/latinamericanhistory/display/10.1093/acrefore/9780199366439.001.0001/acrefore-9780199366439-e-1185?p=emailA6qlFpGrOSEI6&d=/10.1093/acrefore/9780199366439.001.0001/acrefore-9780199366439-e-1185
58. I am a 30 year old Incan running messenger. After years of service, my knees just can't take the abuse anymore. What are my options? : r/AskHistorians - Reddit, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.reddit.com/r/AskHistorians/comments/gi1yw8/i_am_a_30_year_old_incan_running_messenger_after/
59. Chasqui of the 21st Century - Patagonia New Zealand, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.patagonia.co.nz/blogs/stories/chasqui-of-the-21st-century
60. Chasqui of the 21st Century - Patagonia Stories, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.patagonia.com/stories/chasqui-of-the-21st-century/story-126149.html
61. Quechua: The Living Language of the Andes | TreXperience, accessed May 18, 2025, https://trexperienceperu.com/blog/quechua
62. Inca civilization | Archaeology of the Age of Exploration Class Notes - Fiveable, accessed May 18, 2025,

https://library.fiveable.me/archaeology-of-the-age-of-exploration/unit-2/inca-civilization/study-guide/z352VEMrj1L40eXX
63. Inca Quipus - Museo Larco, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.museolarco.org/en/exhibition/permanent-exhibition/online-exhibition/textiles-from-ancient-peru/inca-quipus/
64. Inca Empire for Kids: Government - Ducksters, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.ducksters.com/history/inca/government.php
65. Incas - 6th Grade Social Studies, accessed May 18, 2025, https://nsms6thgradesocialstudies.weebly.com/incas.html
66. Quipus in the colonial era – Museo Chileno de Arte Precolombino *Quipu*: Counting with knots in the Inka Empire – 2003, accessed May 18, 2025, https://precolombino.cl/wp/en/exposiciones/exposiciones-temporales/exposicion-quipu-contar-anudando-en-el-imperio-inka-2003/quipus-durante-la-colonia/
67. Quipu - Inka knots - State of Jefferson Rotary eClub, accessed May 18, 2025, https://stateofjeffersonrotary.org/library/programs-1/1329-quipu-inka-knots.html
68. Third Council of Lima - Wikiwand, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.wikiwand.com/en/articles/Third_Council_of_Lima
69. Talking Knots of the Inka - Archaeology Magazine Archive, accessed May 18, 2025, https://archive.archaeology.org/9611/abstracts/inka.html
70. Last Works, 1500–2000, AAH 2023 (London, 14 Apr 23) - ArtHist.net ..., accessed May 18, 2025, https://arthist.net/archive/38851
71. Long Before the W-2, There Was the Quipu: Accounting Systems of Incan and Andean Peoples | Harvard Library, accessed May 18, 2025, https://library.harvard.edu/about/news/2023-04-12/long-w-2-there-was-quipu-accounting-systems-incan-and-andean-peoples
72. The Inca: The Highest Achievements of Andean Civilization – open ..., accessed May 18, 2025, https://openendedsocialstudies.org/2017/07/30/the-inca-the-highest-achievements-of-andean-civilization/
73. The Inca Khipu: Ancient Data in Knotted Strings - Blog Viagens Machu Picchu, accessed May 18, 2025, https://blog.viajesmachupicchu.travel/en/the-inca-khipu-ancient-data-in-knotted-strings/
74. Inca Garcilaso de la Vega - Wikipedia, accessed May 18, 2025, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Inca_Garcilaso_de_la_Vega
75. 1 WRITING AND RECORD-KEEPING IN THE ANCIENT AMERICAS: THE QUIPUS OF THE ANDES - Pearson Higher Education, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.pearsonhighered.com/assets/samplechapter/0/3/2/1/0321355822.pdf
76. Felipe Guaman Poma de Ayala - Wikipedia, accessed May 18, 2025, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Felipe_Guaman_Poma_de_Ayala
77. Felipe Guamán Poma de Ayala - Wikipedia, la enciclopedia libre, accessed May 18, 2025, https://es.wikipedia.org/wiki/Felipe_Guam%C3%A1n_Poma_de_Ayala
78. El primer nueva corónica y buen gobierno | work by Guamán Poma ..., accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.britannica.com/topic/El-primer-nueva-coronica-y-buen-gobierno

79. Guaman Poma and The First New Chronicle and Good Government ..., accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.khanacademy.org/humanities/art-americas/new-spain/viceroyalty-peru/a/guaman-poma-the-first-new-chronicle
80. Comentarios Reales de los Incas - Wikipedia, accessed May 18, 2025, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Comentarios_Reales_de_los_Incas
81. Comentarios reales de los incas - Wikipedia, la enciclopedia libre, accessed May 18, 2025, https://es.wikipedia.org/wiki/Comentarios_reales_de_los_incas
82. Inca Empire, accessed May 18, 2025, https://peachv.org/index.php/geography-menu-one/rest-world/inca-empire
83. Pacha: An Andean Space-Time Construct, Energized by the Swaps of the Dual Concepts of Urin and Janan, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.worldscientific.com/doi/pdf/10.1142/9789811281938_0001?download=true
84. RESISTANCE TO THE EXPANSION OF PACHAKUTIQ'S ... - OAKTrust, accessed May 18, 2025, https://oaktrust.library.tamu.edu/bitstreams/f5eedc8d-db7c-48a0-b8fb-cf31a8cffcc0/download
85. Spanish conquest of the Inca Empire - Wikipedia, accessed May 18, 2025, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Spanish_conquest_of_the_Inca_Empire
86. Mita System - (Latin American History – 1791 to Present) - Vocab, Definition, Explanations, accessed May 18, 2025, https://fiveable.me/key-terms/latin-america-1791-present/mita-system
87. Nalanda University Destruction - Introduction, Cause and New Start, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.vedantu.com/general-knowledge/bakhtiyar-khilji-destroyed-nalanda-university
88. Turkish Raiders Destroy Buddhist University at Nalanda | EBSCO ..., accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.ebsco.com/research-starters/history/turkish-raiders-destroy-buddhist-university-nalanda
89. Burning of books and burying of scholars - Wikipedia, accessed May 18, 2025, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Burning_of_books_and_burying_of_scholars
90. Do we know what was loss during the 'Burning of Books' in Qin ..., accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.reddit.com/r/AskHistorians/comments/1ic9x4/do_we_know_what_was_loss_during_the_burning_of/
91. Inca mythology - Wikipedia, accessed May 18, 2025, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Inca_mythology
92. The Power of Huacas: Change and Resistance in the Andean World ..., accessed May 18, 2025, https://dokumen.pub/the-power-of-huacas-change-and-resistance-in-the-andean-world-of-colonial-peru-0292756941-9780292756946.html
93. Untangling Memories of Violence: The Khipu in El rincón de los muertos (Alfredo Pita) - Scholars Archive, accessed May 18, 2025,

https://scholarsarchive.library.albany.edu/cgi/viewcontent.cgi?article=1041&context=liljournal
94. The Lost Knowledge of the Ancients: Were Humans the First? | Ancient Origins, accessed May 18, 2025, https://www.ancient-origins.net/history/lost-knowledge-ancients-were-humans-first-part-4-008578